



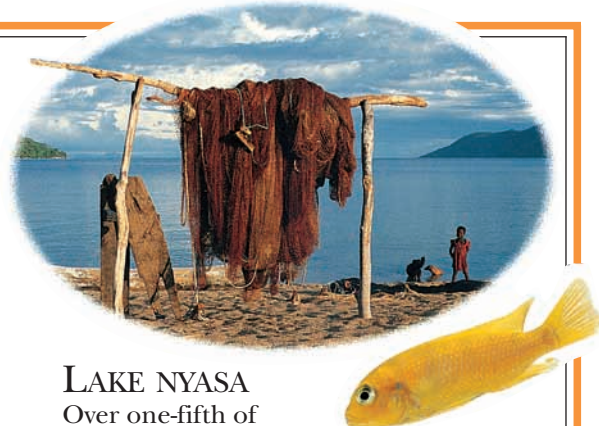
MALAWI

Capital city: Lilongwe
Area: 45,745 sq miles (118,480 sq km)
Population: 12,100,000
Official languages: English
Major religions: Christian 75%, Muslim 20%, traditional beliefs 5%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Malawian kwacha
Adult literacy rate: 62%
Life expectancy: 38 years
People per doctor: 20,000
Televisions: 2 per 1,000 people

MALAWI

LYING ON A PLATEAU at the southern end of the Great Rift Valley, Malawi's six major tribal groups have lived together in relative peace. This was in part due to the harsh rule of the dictator Hastings Banda. Since democracy was introduced in 1994, however, there have been some open political tensions. Malawi's economy is based on agriculture, but the government is trying to encourage the growth of agricultural processing industries, such as food canning and cooking oil manufacture, as well as mining and other heavy industries. New mineral deposits were discovered in 2000.

Many people grow just enough food to feed themselves and their families. If there is any extra produce, they sell it in local markets like this one.



LAKE NYASA

Over one-fifth of Malawi's total area is taken up by Lake Nyasa, one of the largest and deepest lakes in the world.

A huge fishing industry has developed around the lake, which is home to more than 500 species of fish. A sardinelike fish called the usipa is one of the main catches. The fish are dried on the shore and sold throughout Malawi. However, overfishing has meant that there are not enough fish left over for export.

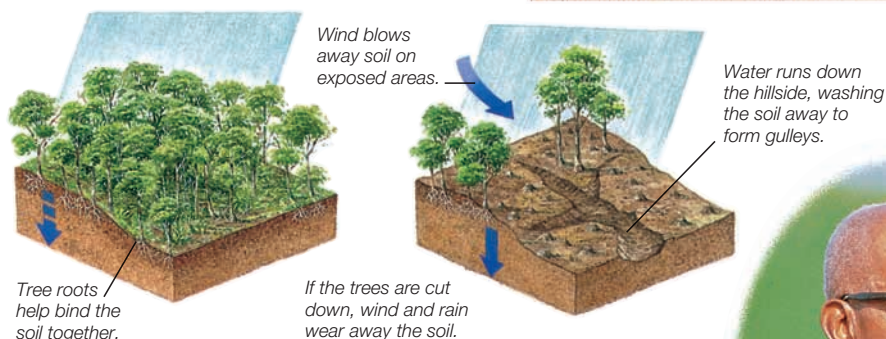
Fishermen collect these brightly colored fish, called cichlids, for export to aquariums around the world.



FARMING

Farming is the most important business in Malawi. Tobacco, tea, and sugar make up 85 percent of exports, and more than 80 percent of Malawi's population makes a living by farming. To increase the land available to farm, swamps have been drained and woodland has been cleared. Rivers have been dammed and wells dug to water dry grasslands. Poor harvests can lead to extreme hardship among Malawi's people.

Soil erosion



FORESTS

Forest and woodland cover nearly half the country, but huge areas have been cut down for fuel and to clear land for farming. Malawi has no oil and little coal, so the most popular fuel is charcoal, made by partially burning wood so that it becomes smokeless and slow-burning. Where more land is needed for farming, trees are cut down and burned, and crops are grown in the ashes. Such land is fertile for only a short time because the forest soil is quickly eroded.

PEOPLE OF MALAWI

Malawi is one of the least urbanized countries in the world, with 85 percent of its population living in villages in the countryside, mostly near seasonal wetlands called *dambos*. Villages are small and are usually made up of people who are closely related. Unlike many other African countries, Malawi's main ethnic groups, the Chewas, Nyanja, Tumbuka, Tonga, Ngonis, and Yao, live together peacefully.

HASTINGS BANDA

For 30 years after achieving independence in 1964, Dr. Hastings Banda was president of Malawi, ruling the country virtually alone. His government helped the country become strong and self-reliant, but other political opinions were not tolerated and many people were tortured or imprisoned. In 1994, democratic elections led to Banda's downfall.



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